Question: Rock-cut architecture as a source of knowledge of early Indian art and history

Assessment based on the submitted two-page answer; score is indicative, not official UPSC marking.

5.5/10

INDICATIVE SCORE

Overall assessment

You understand the broad relevance of rock-cut architecture and organise the answer around several dimensions: religion, society, economy, cultural synthesis and spiritual life. The main limitation is that some points are asserted rather than demonstrated with precise examples. The diagram/map is difficult to interpret, and the conclusion needs a sharper link back to the question's phrase 'sources of knowledge'.

WHAT WORKS

- Relevant opening that addresses art and historical knowledge.
- Multi-dimensional coverage rather than a purely architectural description.
- Attempts to use a map and a chaitya-hall sketch.

PRIORITY IMPROVEMENTS

- Add specific, accurate site-based examples to each major claim.
- Make the map legible and label only locations you can place confidently.
- Explain how the evidence reveals art, social organisation, economy or religion.
- Finish with a direct, analytical conclusion.

Indicative dimension-wise assessment

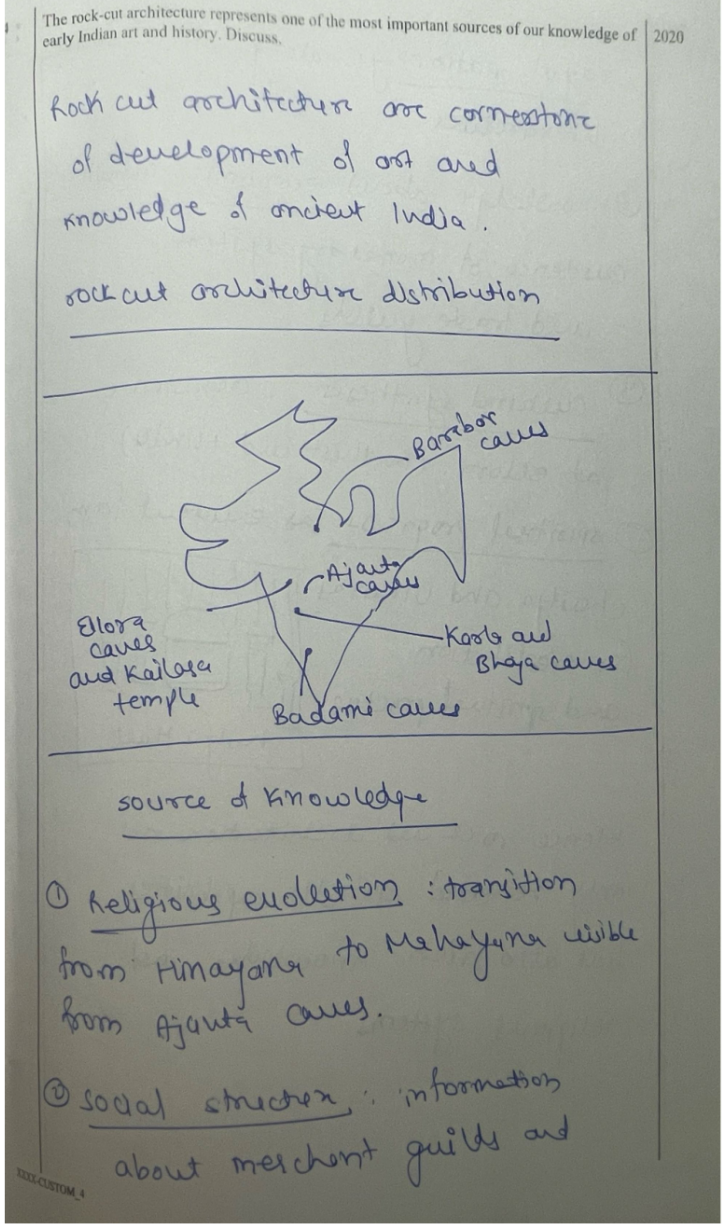
Relevance to question	Good
Structure and organisation	Fair to good
Factual precision and examples	Needs improvement
Diagram/map utility	Needs improvement
Analysis and conclusion	Fair

How to improve this answer in the next rewrite

Use a clear chain: claim → named site/inscription/architectural feature → what it tells us → link to the question.

Keep the diagram simple, and use the conclusion to synthesise the different kinds of historical evidence.

Note: The evaluation is an illustrative examiner-style assessment of the submitted answer, not an official UPSC score.



2–3 HIGH-IMPACT SUGGESTIONS

Original answer preserved on the left

INTRODUCTION

Define rock-cut architecture as spaces such as caves, chaityas and viharas excavated from living rock. Link this directly to art, religion and patronage.

MAP / EXAMPLES

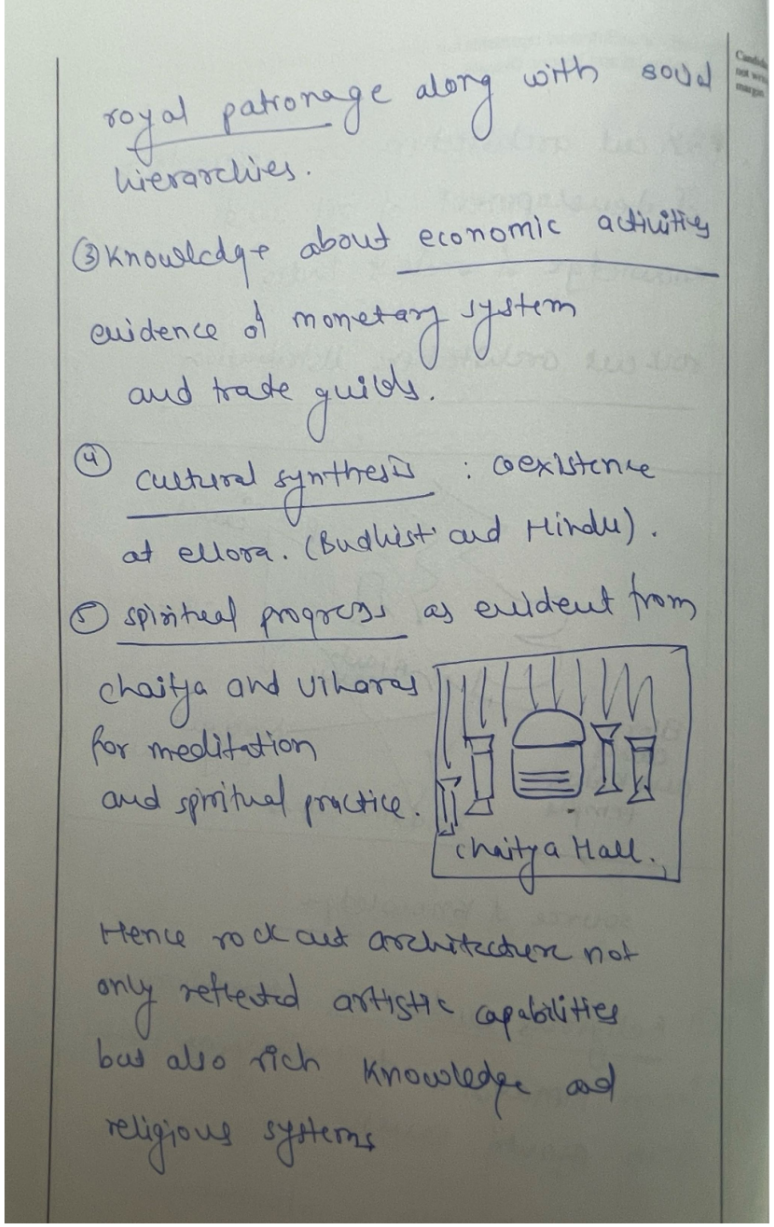
The map is hard to interpret. Use a simple India outline and mark only clear, accurate examples such as Barabar, Ajanta–Ellora and Karla–Bhaja.

EVIDENCE

When mentioning social and economic life, connect donor inscriptions, merchant/guild donations or royal patronage to the specific historical insight each provides.

Indicative: 5.5/10

Use this page for targeted revision of the original answer.



2–3 HIGH-IMPACT SUGGESTIONS

Original answer preserved on the left

RELIGIOUS CHANGE

Qualify the Hinayana–Mahayana point; avoid presenting it as a simple one-step transition. Support it with a specific example from Ajanta's art or inscriptions.

CULTURAL SYNTHESIS

The Ellora example is relevant. Explain what the Buddhist, Hindu and Jain monuments indicate about religious plurality, patronage and shared craftsmanship.

CONCLUSION

End by directly answering the question: rock-cut sites preserve evidence of artistic techniques, religious practice, patronage and social/economic networks.

Indicative: 5.5/10

Use this page for targeted revision of the original answer.